

BIHAR ORIGIN

Baingan Bharta

Bihari-Style Roasted Eggplant Mash
Smoky, Sharp, and Simply Seasoned

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Baingan Bharta

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Baingan Bharta

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Familiar Dish with a Distinctly Bihari Accent

Baingan bharta — roasted, mashed eggplant — appears across much of North India in various forms, but Bihar's version carries its own distinct accent, closely related to the baingan chokha found within the same chokha family as this collection's aloo chokha. Where Punjabi-style bharta typically builds a fuller tomato-onion masala around the roasted eggplant, Bihari baingan bharta stays leaner and sharper, dressed simply with raw mustard oil, garlic, onion, and green chili rather than a cooked gravy.

The technique starts the same way across regions — the eggplant is charred whole over an open flame or roasted until the skin blackens and blisters, giving the flesh inside its essential smoky character — but Bihar's finishing touch keeps things closer to chokha's rustic simplicity than to a fully cooked curry, letting the eggplant's roasted flavor stand largely on its own.

This leaner style reflects a broader thread running through much of Bihari home cooking: a preference for direct, clean flavors built from fewer components, rather than the layered, slow-cooked gravies found in some neighboring culinary traditions — a difference that becomes clear the moment you taste Bihari bharta next to its Punjabi cousin.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Familiar Dish with a Distinctly Bihari Accent, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Closely related to baingan chokha, sharing the Bihari chokha family's preference for simple, raw-dressed mashed vegetables over cooked gravies. Distinguishes itself from Punjabi-style baingan bharta by staying leaner and sharper, without a full tomato-onion masala base. Reflects a broader Bihari culinary preference for direct, clean flavors built from fewer components. A useful dish for understanding how the same basic technique — roasting and mashing eggplant — produces genuinely different regional results across India.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	25m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	ROAST TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Tongs, for open-flame roasting
- Baking sheet, if oven-roasting
- Mixing bowl
- Fork or masher

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Baingan bharta keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days, best enjoyed relatively fresh given its reliance on raw onion, garlic, and mustard oil for brightness. It doesn't freeze well, as the texture and fresh flavors are best shortly after preparation.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Large eggplant (globe or Italian variety)	1 large	500 g	1 large
Onion, finely chopped	1 small	80 g	1 small
Garlic, minced	3 cloves	10 g	3 cloves
Green chili, finely chopped	2	2	2
Tomato, finely chopped — optional	1 small	80 g	1 small
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Lemon juice	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Any large eggplant variety works well for roasting; Italian or globe eggplant is a good widely-available choice outside India. If you don't have a gas flame for direct charring, roasting whole in a very hot oven (450°F / 230°C) until the skin blisters and the flesh is completely soft is a reliable alternative, detailed in the instructions. Mustard oil is important to the dish's authentic sharp character, though a neutral oil with extra lemon can substitute if needed.

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Roasting and Mashing the Eggplant

01 CHAR THE EGGPLANT OVER OPEN FLAME

Pierce the eggplant a few times with a fork, then place it directly over a gas flame, turning occasionally with tongs, until the skin is completely charred and blackened and the flesh feels soft all the way through, about 12–15 minutes.



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Roasting and Mashing the Eggplant, continued

Chef tip. don't rush this step — the eggplant should feel completely collapsed and soft, with no firm patches, for the best smoky flavor and texture.

02 OR ROAST IN THE OVEN

Alternatively, roast the whole eggplant on a baking sheet in a 450°F / 230°C oven for 35–40 minutes, until the skin blisters and the flesh is completely soft — this method won't achieve quite the same smokiness but works well.

03 PEEL AND MASH

Let the roasted eggplant cool slightly, then peel off the charred skin and discard. Mash the flesh with a fork, leaving some texture rather than a completely smooth puree.

04 MIX IN THE AROMATICS

While the eggplant is still warm, mix in the chopped onion, garlic, green chili, tomato if using, and coriander — the residual warmth helps release the aromatics' flavor.

Texture indicator. the finished bharta should be a rustic, slightly chunky mash with visible flecks of char, not a completely smooth puree.

05 FINISH WITH MUSTARD OIL AND LEMON

Drizzle in the mustard oil and lemon juice, season with salt, and mix thoroughly. Taste and adjust the balance of tang, heat, and pungency to your preference.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Roasting and Mashing the Eggplant, continued



MISTAKE TO AVOID

Undercooking the eggplant leaves a bitter, unpleasant flesh that no amount of seasoning can fully fix. Make sure it's completely soft and collapsed before proceeding — better to over-roast slightly than under-roast.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served with roti or rice, a simple, everyday Bihari dish valued for its direct, smoky flavor.
- Often part of a chokha trio alongside aloo chokha and tomato chokha for a varied vegetarian spread.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A shared bowl at the table alongside litti, rice, or roti for everyone to help themselves.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a smoky, rustic dip alongside flatbread for a non-traditional appetizer presentation.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Smoke Right

- Open-flame charring genuinely produces a deeper smoky flavor than oven roasting — worth the slightly messier process if you have a gas stove.
- Mixing the aromatics in while the eggplant is warm, not hot or cold, gives the best flavor infusion.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Roast the eggplant ahead of time and refrigerate, then mash and season fresh just before serving for the brightest flavor.
- This dish comes together quickly once the eggplant is roasted, making it practical even on busy days.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks roast the onion and garlic briefly alongside the eggplant over the open flame before mixing everything together, adding an extra layer of smoky depth throughout the dish.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

115 kcal	2 g	10 g	8 g	4 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Bihari Baingan Chokha	an even simpler version, closer to the chokha family, without tomato.
Baingan Bharta with Tomato	the version featured here, with a small amount of tomato for extra brightness.
Smoky Baingan Bharta	an extra-charred version for those who especially love the smoky flavor, roasted slightly longer.

Why does my bharta taste bitter?

Usually undercooked eggplant. Make sure it's completely soft and collapsed before peeling and mashing.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

How is this different from Punjabi baingan bharta?

Bihari-style bharta stays leaner and sharper, dressed with raw mustard oil and aromatics rather than a cooked tomato-onion masala gravy typical of Punjabi versions.

Can I make this without an open flame?

Yes — oven roasting at high heat works well, detailed in the instructions, though it won't achieve quite the same smokiness as open-flame charring.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Baingan	Hindi for eggplant, the primary vegetable in this dish.
Chokha	Bihar's tradition of mashed, spiced vegetable dishes, closely related to this preparation.
Sorson Tel	Hindi for mustard oil, essential to authentic flavor in this dish.
Bharta	a general term across North India for a mashed, roasted vegetable dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Baingan Bharta

10m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	ROAST TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Large eggplant	500 g
Onion	80 g
Garlic	10 g
Green chili	2
Tomato	80 g
Fresh coriander	8 g
Mustard oil	45 ml
Lemon juice	15 ml
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Char the eggplant over open flame.** Pierce the eggplant a few times with a fork, then place it directly over a gas flame, turning occasionally with tongs, until the skin is completely charred and blackened and the flesh feels soft all the way through, about 12–15 minutes.

02 **Or roast in the oven.** Alternatively, roast the whole eggplant on a baking sheet in a 450°F / 230°C oven for 35–40 minutes, until the skin blisters and the flesh is completely soft — this method won't achieve quite the same smokiness but works well.

03 **Peel and mash.** Let the roasted eggplant cool slightly, then peel off the charred skin and discard.

04 **Mix in the aromatics.** While the eggplant is still warm, mix in the chopped onion, garlic, green chili, tomato if using, and coriander — the residual warmth helps release the aromatics' flavor.

05 **Finish with mustard oil and lemon.** Drizzle in the mustard oil and lemon juice, season with salt, and mix thoroughly.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Large eggplant	500 g	☐ Onion	80 g
☐ Garlic	10 g	☐ Green chili	2
☐ Tomato	80 g	☐ Fresh coriander	8 g
☐ Mustard oil	45 ml	☐ Lemon juice	15 ml
☐ Salt	6 g		

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